CAPSTONE, PORTFOLIO & INTERVIEWS · LESSON 4 OF 10

Your 90-Day Plan: Learning Roadmap, Job Search Strategy and Growing in Your First Role

Turn this handbook into a job. A week-by-week 90-day study and project plan for analyst, data science and GenAI tracks, a weekly routine, a job-search funnel with referrals and outreach messages, salary research and negotiation basics, and habits that help you grow in the first 6 months on the job.

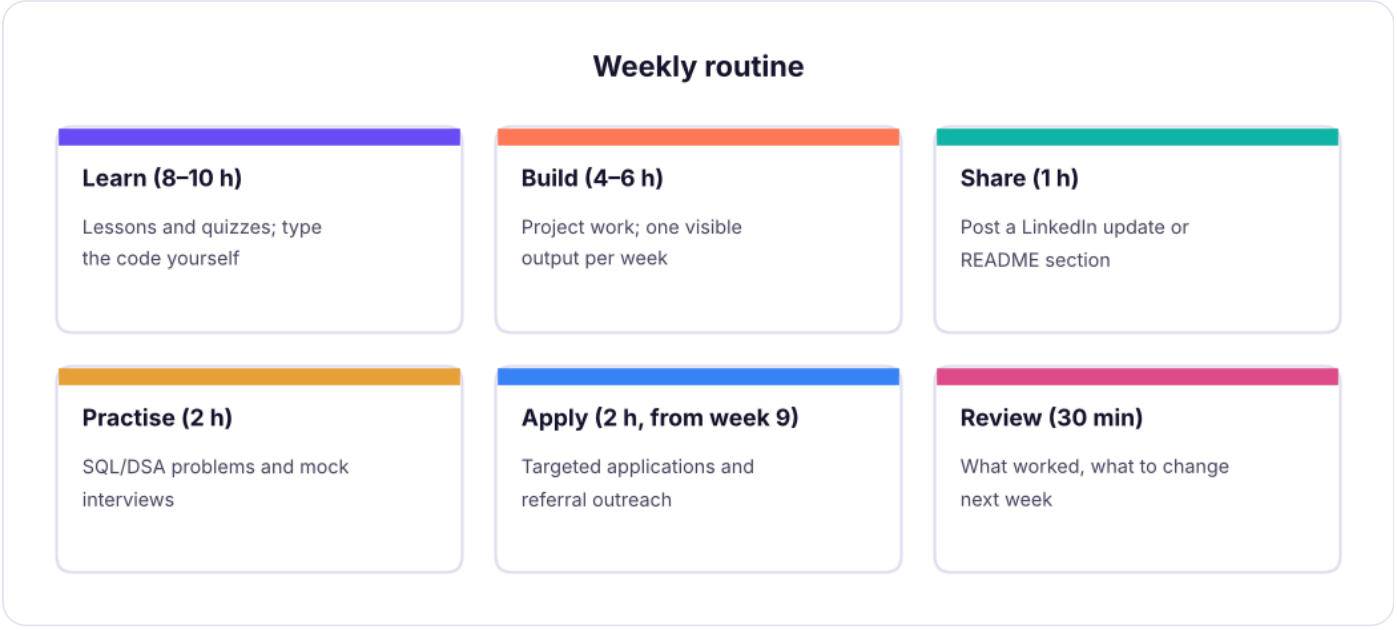
Career track · ✦ 2026 · Beginner · ⏱ 60 min

By the end of this lesson you can

- Follow a realistic 90-day roadmap with weekly goals
- Run a job-search funnel with referrals and targeted applications
- Prepare for salary discussions with market data
- Build habits for success in the first months of a data role

90-day roadmap

Weeks	Analyst track	Data science / ML track	GenAI track
1–2	Excel lessons 1–6	Python 1–10	Python 1–12
3–4	Excel 7–12 + SQL 1–5	Python 15–22 (NumPy, pandas, EDA)	Python 15–19, 23–24 (APIs)
5–6	SQL 6–15 + SQL case study	Stats ML 1–6 (statistics, A/B)	GenAI 1–4 (LLMs, prompts, APIs, embeddings)
7–8	Power BI 1–6 + dashboard project	ML 7–15 (workflow, regression, metrics, CV)	GenAI 5–8 (RAG, tools, agents, MCP)
9–10	Python 1–16, 20–22	ML 16–25 + one capstone	GenAI 9–12 + capstone app
11–12	AI analytics 1–4, portfolio polish	ML 26–28, portfolio polish	Portfolio, deployment, write-ups
13	Interview prep (Career 2) and applications	Interview prep (Career 3)	Interview prep (Career 3)



A sustainable weekly routine.

Job-search funnel

Stage	Target per week	Tips
Research companies and roles	15	Match your projects to their domain
Referral / recruiter outreach	10	Personalised messages; alumni and community contacts
Applications	10–15	Tailor resume keywords; apply within 3 days of posting
Screens and tests	2–4	Track results; review mistakes
Interviews	1–3	Prepare company-specific cases

Referral message template:

```text
Hi <Name>, I'm a data analyst (SQL, Power BI, Python) who built <project link> on <domain>.
I saw the <role> opening at <company> (job id). Could you refer me or share what the team
values most?
Happy to send my one-page resume. Thank you!
```

Track everything in a simple sheet: company, role, date, source, status, next step, notes.

Salary and offers

Research ranges on AmbitionBox, Glassdoor, LinkedIn Salary and peers for your city and experience. Ask for the full CTC breakdown (fixed, variable, joining bonus, benefits), negotiate on evidence (skills, competing offers, market data), and compare learning opportunities, team quality and growth, not only salary.

First 90 days in the job

1. Learn the business: products, customers, key metrics and their definitions.
2. Find the data: sources, owners, known quality issues; document as you go.
3. Deliver a small, useful win in the first month.
4. Communicate: weekly updates, clear charts with insight titles, assumptions stated.
5. Automate repetitive reports; share reusable SQL and notebooks.
6. Keep learning: one new skill per quarter (dbt, cloud, experimentation, GenAI).

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Follow the 90-day roadmap with a weekly routine of learn, build, share, practise and apply.
- Run the job search as a funnel with referrals, tailored applications and tracking.
- Negotiate with market data and evaluate the whole offer.
- In the new role, learn the business, deliver early wins, communicate clearly and keep learning.

Quick quiz

3 questions · tap an answer to check it

1. What should each week of the plan produce?

A At least one visible output (project progress, write-up or dashboard)

B Only reading

C Only certificates

D Nothing until week 12

Answer: A. Evidence compounds.

2. Which outreach is most effective?

A Personalised referral requests linking a relevant project

B Generic mass messages

C Applying to every job without reading it

D Waiting for recruiters

Answer: A. Relevance wins.

3. What matters when comparing offers?

- **A** Full CTC breakdown plus learning, team and growth
- **B** Only the fixed salary
- **C** Only the company logo
- **D** Only the job title

Answer: A. Look at the whole package.

EXERCISE **Practice**

Write your personal 13-week plan with weekly goals, choose your capstone, create your job-tracker sheet, and send three referral messages this week.

Show solution (worked answer)

A good plan names the lessons, the project deliverable and the job-search target for every week, with time blocked in your calendar.

Practise more online

Free, trusted places to test yourself on this topic. Links open the original site in a new tab.